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From online to offline: how web-based brand stimuli shape the physical store experience in omnichannel fashion retail

Coral Cenizo

Department of Business Economics, School of Economics and Business, San Pablo CEU University, CEU Universities, Madrid, Spain

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Abstract

Purpose – This study investigates how experiences generated in digital environments – specifically perceived personalization and brand sensory experience – impact the experiential value of physical in-store interactions within the fashion industry. Additionally, it examines the extent to which consumer sensory orientation modulates these effects in omnichannel contexts.

Design/methodology/approach – A quantitative research design was employed, structured around an experiment combining a simulated digital shopping journey, in-person exposure, and the administration of a standardized questionnaire. The sample, consisting of 445 participants, was recruited through Prolific. Data were analyzed using exploratory and confirmatory factor analyses (EFA and CFA), hierarchical regression models, and interaction tests with bootstrapping, ensuring psychometric robustness and external validity.

Findings – The results reveal that digital personalization, when lacking coherent sensory alignment, may diminish the perceived value of the in-store experience. Conversely, the online brand sensory experience significantly enhances such valuation. Furthermore, consumers with high sensory orientation amplify these effects: they exhibit greater positive responsiveness to sensory stimuli and lower receptivity to personalizations perceived as generic or intrusive.

Originality/value – The primary contribution of this study lies in integrating, within a single explanatory model, the effects of digital experiences on physical evaluations through a sensory and personalized lens. By introducing consumer sensory orientation as a moderating variable, this research advances understanding of omnichannel behavior and offers a more nuanced perspective on the design of effective hybrid experiences in the retail sector. It provides both theoretical insights and managerial implications in a landscape increasingly shaped by technological convergence.

Keywords Brand experience, Communication, Consumer behavior, E-commerce, Experiential value, Fashion retail, Omnichannel strategy, Sensory orientation

Paper type Research article

1. Introduction

The digitalization of retail in the fashion sector—driven by e-commerce and interactive technologies—has transformed consumer engagement, increasingly shaped by personalized and sensory experiences. The omnichannel approach integrates digital and physical environments into a continuous journey requiring emotional consistency across touchpoints (Fuentes *et al*., 2017; Grewal *et al*., 2017).

Although digital stimuli like algorithmic personalization and sensory branding enhance content relevance and brand recall (Baek and Morimoto, 2012), research tends to focus on digital-only contexts, overlooking how these elements influence in-store evaluations. Many models assume a seamless value transfer across channels, ignoring potential perceptual shifts during the transition between digital and physical spaces (Picot-Coupey *et al*., 2016; Gallino and Moreno, 2014).

This gap is crucial. Omnichannel success depends not only on technical integration but also on emotionally coherent experiences. Despite advances in personalization, its impact on physical retail perceptions remains unclear, particularly concerning individual traits such as sensory orientation. The lack of empirical evidence limits academic progress and strategic design in hybrid brand experiences (Guercini and Runfola, 2015; Beck and Crié, 2018).

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From a managerial perspective, behaviors like webrooming—where consumers research online before buying in-store—highlight these challenges. Highly personalized or immersive online experiences may raise offline expectations; if unmet, perceptual dissonance and symbolic misalignment can arise.

This study examines how digital experiences—specifically perceived personalization and online sensory brand stimulation—influence in-store evaluations. It also explores the moderating role of sensory orientation, an individual trait that may alter the effects of digital stimuli. Two research questions guide the inquiry:

RQ1. How do perceived personalization and brand sensory experience in digital environments shape the experiential value attributed to in-store interactions?

RQ2. To what extent does consumer sensory orientation modulate the impact of digital experiences on evaluations of the physical retail experience?

The study contributes by integrating these variables into an empirical model addressing gaps in omnichannel research. Sensory orientation is introduced as a moderating factor often overlooked, despite its relevance in shaping emotional and symbolic perceptions (Aron *et al.*, 2012; Grimen and Diseth, 2016). This framework advances understanding of digital–physical experience interplay and informs coherent omnichannel strategy design.

2. Theoretical background

2.1 Consumer experiential value

Consumer experiential value is conceptualized as a subjective and multidimensional construct arising from sensory, affective, cognitive, and social interactions throughout consumption. Unlike utilitarian value, it centers on symbolic and emotional meaning-making and encompasses hedonic, symbolic, and relational dimensions beyond functional performance (Holbrook, 1999; Pendleton, 2009; Lai and Zhou, 2009).

Prior research has predominantly examined in-store experiential value through environmental, technological, and psychological antecedents (see Table 1), while largely overlooking how prior online experiences—particularly personalized ones—shape consumer interpretations in physical retail settings.

This gap is increasingly salient in the context of multichannel behaviors such as webrooming and showrooming, which generate continuous customer journeys across digital and physical environments (Van Nguyen *et al.*, 2024; Melis *et al.*, 2015). In these journeys, online experiences function less as informational tools and more as experiential framing mechanisms. Personalization algorithms and immersive digital content shape anticipatory

Table 1. Antecedents of in-store experience identified in prior research

Category	Antecedent variables	Representative studies
Environmental	Lighting, layout, design, color, sound, cleanliness	Norouzi *et al.* (2016), Cuong (2019)
Human/Service	Employee cheerfulness, expertise, helpfulness	Norouzi *et al.* (2016), Widjaja and Kusuma (2018)
Economic	Price fairness, value, reward perception	Sihotang and Ellyawati (2020)
Psychological	Shopping motives, materialism, socio-demographics	Isham and Jackson (2023), Swathi and Rao (2019)
Technological	In-store tech usefulness, ease of use	Singh and Yadav (2025)
Brand/ Relational	Trust, commitment, store image	Demirgunes (2016)

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beliefs by enhancing perceived recognition, symbolic alignment, and atmospheric expectations, often simulating sensory qualities traditionally associated with physical retail (Razak, 2023; Nadeem, 2024; Okuda and Rybak, 2023). Accordingly, positioning web personalization and online sensory brand experience as predictors of in-store experiential value responds both to a theoretical omission and to contemporary omnichannel practices.

To explain this process, the study draws on Expectancy-Disconfirmation Theory (EDT), which posits that experiential value results from comparisons between expectations and perceived performance (Oliver, 1980). In omnichannel contexts, digitally mediated interactions generate expectations regarding the emotional and sensory qualities of the in-store experience. When these expectations are confirmed, experiential value is reinforced; when they are not, perceptual dissonance arises.

This mechanism is particularly relevant in fashion retail, where experiential value is inherently symbolic and sensory. Digital interfaces increasingly communicate uniqueness, intimacy, aesthetic coherence, and sustainability narratives as part of the experiential proposition (Luna Garcia *et al*., 2025). However, recent research highlights the ambivalent nature of personalization: while it may increase engagement, it also heightens the risk of dissonance when offline environments fail to validate digitally induced expectations (Gogua and Smirnova, 2020; Nadeem, 2024). When perceived as intrusive or symbolically misaligned, personalization may undermine authenticity (Zhu *et al*., 2022; Van Nguyen *et al*., 2024), making emotional coherence across touchpoints critical.

Although the effects of personalization on online engagement have been widely studied (He *et al*., 2020), less attention has been given to how digital expectations—whether aesthetic, personalized, or sustainability-related—condition evaluations of physical experiences. Online touchpoints, including reviews and curated content, act as precursors that shape offline perceptions (Chen *et al*., 2022; Bo *et al*., 2023; Razak, 2023; Melis *et al*., 2015). In particular, online reviews influence offline behavior through emotional arousal, credibility, and group similarity, with negative reviews attracting disproportionate attention and generating anticipatory bias (Fernandes *et al*., 2022; Maslowska *et al*., 2017; Chen *et al*., 2022).

Despite this evidence, limited research has examined how digital personalization and symbolic promises may intensify disconfirmation when sensory, ethical, or experiential expectations are unmet in-store. This limitation is especially pronounced in emerging markets, where rapid digitalization coexists with heterogeneous retail infrastructures and culturally diverse experiential norms (Hollebeek *et al*., 2022).

Building on these insights, this study extends the experiential value framework to omnichannel settings by modeling how digital personalization and online sensory brand experience generate expectations that condition in-store evaluations. By incorporating individual perceptual traits, it moves beyond uniform assumptions of experiential value formation and offers a more differentiated understanding of cross-channel experience construction.

2.2 Sensory processing

Sensory processing refers to how individuals perceive, organize, and interpret stimuli, including stable interindividual differences in sensitivity. In consumption contexts, it conditions how meaning is assigned to multisensory environments. Sensory marketing highlights that brand experience arises from subjective integration of visual, auditory, tactile, olfactory, and gustatory cues, beyond functional attributes (Hultén, 2015; Farhadi *et al*., 2012).

While studies confirm that coherent sensory environments enhance brand differentiation, emotional engagement, and loyalty in physical retail (Hassan and Iqbal, 2016), limited research examines sensory processing in digital or hybrid contexts. Despite the growing use of sensory cues in online interfaces—via aesthetics, interactivity, or personalized content—their impact on offline experiences remains underexplored, particularly in high-materiality categories like fashion (Hultén *et al*., 2009).

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This gap is analytically significant when considering how digital sensory inputs shape expectations. Based on Schema Theory, online sensory brand experiences activate perceptual schemas regarding how the brand "should feel" in-store, influencing expectation confirmation or disconfirmation (EDT framework).

AI-driven retail tools such as virtual try-ons, personalized visuals, and interactive storytelling amplify the vividness of these expectations (Tom Dieck and Han, 2022; Annapareddy *et al*., 2025). Although such tools enrich digital engagement, they also heighten the risk of dissonance when physical stores fail to meet the expectations they generate.

Importantly, consumers differ in sensory orientation—defined as a predisposition to experience stimuli with heightened intensity. High sensory orientation individuals form more vivid mental imagery and detect cross-channel inconsistencies more acutely, making them more susceptible to perceptual dissonance when offline experiences fail to deliver on online sensory promises.

Yet, sensory orientation remains largely absent in omnichannel studies, especially in relation to digital personalization. Algorithmic personalization intensifies symbolic and sensory tailoring, increasing both the potential for experiential coherence and the risk of disconfirmation. Ignoring sensory orientation may obscure essential mechanisms in cross-channel experience evaluation.

This study extends sensory processing theory by introducing sensory orientation as a psychographic moderator in omnichannel contexts. It provides a differentiated understanding of how sensory expectations formed online are evaluated offline, depending on perceptual sensitivity. In doing so, it proposes a novel framework for analyzing experiential coherence and dissonance in hybrid retail environments (see Table 2).

Table 2. Research gaps in prior literature and contributions of the present study

Identified research gap	Supporting evidence from literature	How the present study addresses it
1. Prior research on channel coherence focuses on functional alignment (e.g. logistics, interface design), neglecting emotional and sensory consistency	Nadeem (2024), Razak (2023), Melis *et al*. (2015) underscore seamless omnichannel experiences but concentrate on usability and convenience	This study conceptualizes and empirically tests emotional and sensory coherence across digital and physical channels, expanding beyond functional concerns
2. Digital personalization is predominantly viewed as beneficial, with limited attention to its negative impact when expectations are unmet in physical environments	Zhu *et al*. (2022), Gogua and Smirnova (2020), Kaushik and Sharma (2023) highlight privacy-personalization tensions and cognitive overload but do not address cross-channel dissonance	The study frames personalization as a dual-impact predictor, demonstrating its potential to generate dissonance in the physical store when sensory expectations set online are violated
3. Existing models insufficiently integrate digital sensory experiences with physical retail outcomes such as experiential value or satisfaction	Singh and Yadav (2025) note limited crossover between in-store tech and online sensory stimuli; Fernandes *et al*. (2022) develop online impact scales without addressing cross-channel transfer	This research proposes a unified model linking online sensory brand experience to offline experiential value, capturing both direct and interaction effects
4. Little emphasis has been placed on psychographic moderators that explain cross-channel variability, with most studies focused on attitudes, demographics, or trust	Bo *et al*. (2023), Ahn and Lee (2024), Isham and Jackson (2023) explore review valence, self-construal, and materialism but omit sensory predispositions	The study introduces consumer sensory orientation as a novel moderator, enriching explanatory scope and adding depth to omnichannel experience theory

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3. Hypotheses

3.1 Personalization and experiential value of in-store interaction

Perceived personalization in digital environments refers to consumers' perception that online content is tailored to their preferences. Algorithmically driven hyper-personalization enhances relevance, uniqueness, and symbolic alignment (Saksena, 2024; Peteva, 2023). In digital-only contexts, it has been associated with greater trust, perceived control, and experiential value, particularly when perceived as contextually appropriate and helpful (Alimamy and Gnoth, 2022; Gwinner *et al*., 2005; Riegger *et al*., 2022). However, these effects may not seamlessly transfer to omnichannel settings, where expectations formed online are evaluated against the sensory and symbolic dimensions of in-store experiences (Riegger, 2020; Tyrväinen *et al*., 2020; Lemon and Verhoef, 2016).

From the perspective of Expectancy-Disconfirmation Theory (EDT), hyper-personalized digital experiences act as expectation-setting mechanisms. By simulating recognition and exclusivity, they generate anticipatory schemas that guide evaluations of the physical store. When the in-store environment lacks sensory richness, symbolic coherence, or personalization, disconfirmation occurs, potentially reducing experiential value.

This study does not question the general value of personalization but focuses on the consequences of cross-channel disconfirmation. In hybrid contexts, personalization may shift from a driver of engagement to a source of disappointment when physical experiences fail to match digitally induced expectations. This perspective challenges the assumption of personalization as inherently positive, highlighting its dual potential in omnichannel environments.

Therefore:

H1. Perceived personalization on brand websites is negatively associated with the experiential value of in-store interaction.

3.2 Sensory brand experience and the experiential value of in-store interaction

Sensory brand experience in digital environments involves using visual, auditory, and interactive stimuli to evoke sensory associations and emotional responses. In fashion retail, these elements are increasingly aligned with brand identity to simulate physical experiences through immersive design (Shahid *et al*., 2022; Gulati and Roy, 2021; Alexander and Nobbs, 2020).

Evidence shows that effectiveness depends less on stimulus intensity than on coherence with brand image and positioning (Duong *et al*., 2022). However, outcomes vary by store format, sector, consumer profile, and the sense engaged (Clarke *et al*., 2012; Torabi *et al*., 2021; Berman *et al*., 2023).

According to Schema Theory, online sensory cues activate mental representations that shape interpretations of subsequent physical experiences. These schemas encompass expectations regarding atmosphere, product presentation, and emotional tone. When the physical store confirms these schemas—via congruent aesthetics, multisensory elements, or atmospheric design—it fosters perceptual fluency, reinforces brand meaning, and enhances experiential value.

Unlike personalization, which may induce dissonance through unmet symbolic promises, online sensory experience acts as a priming mechanism. Cross-channel coherence increases the likelihood of expectation confirmation and strengthens the perceived quality of in-store interactions.

This way, we posed that:

H2. Sensory brand experience on websites increases the experiential value of in-store interaction.

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3.3 Moderating role of consumer sensory orientation

Consumer sensory orientation is a stable psychographic trait denoting predisposition to perceive, process, and respond to environmental stimuli (Sayadi *et al*., 2015). It comprises aesthetic sensitivity, ease of excitation, and low sensory threshold (Grimen and Diseth, 2016), and influences interpretations of brand atmospheres and multisensory cues.

Empirical research shows that sensory orientation modulates emotional, cognitive, and behavioral responses to identical stimuli, confirming perception is filtered through personal sensory schemas (Li *et al*., 2019; Berman *et al*., 2023). Studies on sensory nudges further demonstrate that environmental cues are interpreted and acted upon differently depending on sensory sensitivity (Seo, 2020).

Within Schema Theory and Expectancy-Disconfirmation, sensory orientation functions as a moderator in cross-channel experiences. High-sensitivity individuals form vivid expectations from digital interactions and seek coherence across touchpoints, leading to stronger confirmation effects when expectations are met—or increased dissonance when they are not.

Such consumers also engage more emotionally and symbolically, attributing meanings like exclusivity or authenticity to sensory cues (Cross *et al*., 2015; Torabi *et al*., 2021). In contrast, low-orientation individuals exhibit attenuated responses, limited schema activation, and lower sensitivity to inconsistencies between digital and physical channels.

Accordingly, this study hypothesizes that consumer sensory orientation moderates the effect of both personalization and digital sensory brand experience on in-store experiential evaluations:

H3. Consumer sensory orientation negatively moderates the relationship between perceived personalization on brand websites and the experiential value of in-store interaction.

H4. Consumer sensory orientation positively moderates the relationship between sensory brand experience on websites and the experiential value of in-store interaction.

The proposed conceptual framework is presented in Figure 1.

4. Methodology

This study adopts a quantitative, cross-sectional design with deductive logic. A structured survey was employed to enable standardized, replicable measurement suited to generalization (Fowler, 2013; Churchill, 1979). The exclusive use of self-reporting is justified by the symbolic and affective nature of the constructs examined, which require subjective interpretation rather than behavioral observation. Ecological validity was prioritized through the use of real brands in naturalistic settings, precluding techniques like eye-tracking or *in situ* behavioral analysis. Logistical and ethical constraints also limited the feasibility of physiological or observational methods. These limitations, especially regarding data triangulation, are discussed in the limitations section.

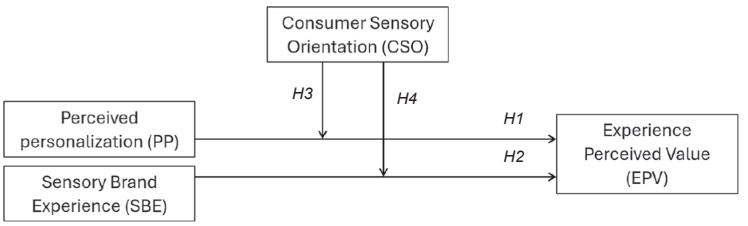


Figure 1. Conceptual model. Source: Authors' own work

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To ensure relevance, inclusion criteria required participants to be adults with prior experience shopping for fashion items both online and offline. This dual-channel experience was essential to assess perceived expectation transfer from digital to physical retail (Rahmawati and Arifin, 2022; Saksena, 2024). A non-probabilistic quota sampling method was used, controlling for these criteria. After data cleaning, 445 valid responses were retained (retention rate: 70.74%). Demographic details are provided in Table 3.

A pilot test was conducted with an independent group to refine item wording and ensure alignment with theoretical dimensions. Following Churchill's (1979) guidelines, the questionnaire was content-validated. Before participation, respondents confirmed they had visited a physical fashion store in the previous six months to ensure experiential familiarity.

Although the study is deductive and quantitative, it does not follow a fully experimental design. Rather, it uses a quasi-experimental, cross-sectional structure with simulated exposure. No stimuli were manipulated; instead, participants recalled a standardized experience. This allowed exploration of variable relationships without random assignment. The procedure sought to activate recent experiential memory, enabling subjective evaluation of digital–physical brand interaction.

Participants were instructed to simulate a browsing experience on a fashion brand website—up to the shopping cart—and then visit the corresponding physical store. Brand choice was left open to preserve authenticity and relevance, reflecting actual consumer–brand relationships. While this reduces control over variables like brand positioning (e.g. luxury vs. fast fashion), it aligns with the study's ecological validity goals. The approach approximates cognitive and affective states consistent with omnichannel experiences, even if no purchase occurred. The questionnaire was administered digitally under standardized conditions.

Causal inference is limited; the design allows for identification of moderate associations within the theoretical framework. The trade-off between ecological realism and experimental control is justified given the study's exploratory focus on symbolic and sensory perceptions in hybrid environments. Using real brands in authentic contexts ensures high ecological validity, particularly relevant in research on symbolically rich consumption. Logistical constraints also restricted the direct manipulation of personalization or sensory stimuli, which would have required collaboration with technologically advanced firms. The simulated exposure method is thus appropriate for capturing complex, subjective constructs.

Table 3. Demographic characteristics of the sample

Variable	Category	N	(%)
Gender	Male	218	49.0%
	Female	222	49.9%
	Not defined	5	1.1%
Age	20–30	153	34.4%
	31–40	126	28.3%
	41–50	95	21.3%
	More than 50	71	16.0%
Country	Latin America and the Caribbean	157	35.3%
	Asia	163	36.6%
	Africa	125	28.1%
Familiarity with e-commerce	High (frequent online purchases)	203	45.6%
	Medium (occasional online purchases)	169	38.0%
	Low (sporadic or recent purchases)	73	16.4%

Source(s): Authors' own work

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The study followed the ethical principles of the Declaration of Helsinki and complied with EU GDPR guidelines. Participants were informed about the study's objectives, its non-invasive nature, and their right to withdraw. Anonymity and data confidentiality were fully guaranteed.

4.1 Measures

Measurement scales were selected based on established frameworks to capture consumer responses across digital and physical brand experiences (Table 4).

Experiential value of in-store interaction was measured using an adaptation of the Experiential Value Scale (EVS) (Mathwick *et al*., 2001), based on Holbrook's (1999) typology. The EVS integrates hedonic (e.g. enjoyment, escapism) and functional (e.g. efficiency, service quality) dimensions, offering a nuanced assessment of aesthetic, emotional, and pragmatic components. Compared to PERVAL (Sweeney and Soutar, 2001), GLOVAL (Sánchez *et al*., 2006), or CEXPVALS (Varshneya and Das, 2017), it demonstrates greater sensitivity in multisensory retail contexts.

Perceived personalization was assessed through a contextualized version of Baek and Morimoto's (2012) scale, adapted for fashion e-commerce. Sensory brand experience was measured using a composite scale adapted from Gao and Lan (2020), Ellen *et al*. (2000), Netemeyer *et al*. (2004), and Bruhn *et al*. (2012), assessing sensory activation and congruence between digital stimuli (e.g. design, sound, visuals) and the consumer's identity, values, and goals.

Finally, sensory orientation was measured using the Highly Sensitive Person Scale (HSPS) (Aron and Aron, 1997a, b), covering emotional reactivity, low sensory threshold, and depth of processing.

4.2 Reliability and validity of the instrument

To validate the structure of the theoretical model, both exploratory (EFA) and confirmatory factor analyses (CFA) were performed (Table 5).

The EFA assessed the adequacy of item sets in representing latent constructs. The Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin (KMO) index was 0.985, indicating excellent sampling adequacy. Bartlett's test of sphericity was significant ($\chi^2 = 52{,}368.078$; df = 1830; $p < 0.001$), confirming that the correlation matrix was suitable for factor analysis.

Communalities exceeded 0.85 for all items, with most above 0.90, indicating strong content validity and specificity. Principal component analysis with varimax rotation yielded a four-factor solution explaining 89.87% of total variance (Figure 2), surpassing conventional methodological thresholds. The first component accounted for 39.18%, followed by 26.17%, 17.27%, and 7.25%, respectively. No cross-loadings or factorial ambiguities were observed.

Factor loadings were consistently high and statistically significant, confirming strong item–construct alignment. Also, internal reliability was excellent, as shown by Cronbach's alpha values. These coefficients indicate high internal consistency and minimal measurement error.

The CFA confirmed the model's validity in terms of overall fit and measurement quality. The Cmin/df ratio was 1.238 (Cmin = 2182.357; df = 1763), indicating excellent parsimony. The RMR index was 0.044, suggesting minimal residual discrepancy. Incremental fit indices also supported model robustness: GFI = 0.868, NFI = 0.960, IFI, TLI, and CFI = 0.992. The RMSEA was 0.023, well below the 0.05 threshold, reinforcing the model's validity regarding approximation error.

Composite reliability was high for all constructs, indicating low measurement error. Convergent validity was confirmed through AVE. Each value exceeded the 0.50 threshold, confirming that items reliably reflect their latent constructs.

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Table 4. Constructs and measures used in the research

Constructs	Items	Sources
Experience Perceived Value (EPV)	*Visual Appeal* EPV1. The way in which the store arranges and presents its products is visually appealing. EPV2. The interior design of the store is aesthetically pleasing. EPV3. I find the appearance of the physical store to be attractive *Entertainment Value* EPV4. I consider visiting the store to be an entertaining experience. EPV5. The store's atmosphere is uplifting and energizing. EPV6. The store offers more than just products—it provides stimulation and engagement *Escapism* EPV7. Spending time in the store helps me disconnect from everyday concerns. EPV8. Visiting the store feels like entering a different world. EPV9. I become so immersed in the store experience that I forget about everything else *Intrinsic Enjoyment* EPV10. I enjoy going to the store for its own sake, not just for making purchases. EPV11. I visit the store because I genuinely enjoy the experience *Efficiency* EPV12. Shopping at the store is an efficient way to manage my time. EPV13. The store simplifies my life. EPV14. Visiting the store fits conveniently into my schedule *Economic Value* EPV15. The products offered by the store provide good value for money. EPV16. Overall, I am satisfied with the prices at this store. EPV17. Considering the quality, I do not find the store to be overpriced	Mathwick *et al.* (2001)
Perceived personalization (PP)	PP1. The product recommendations I receive while browsing the website align with my personal needs. PP2. I perceive that the online store assists me in discovering products that are tailored to me. PP3. Overall, the content of this website appears to be customized to my specific circumstances. PP4. The personalized experience offered by the website makes me feel like a distinct and valued customer. PP5. I believe the website adjusts its content and recommendations based on my preferences and needs	Baek and Morimoto (2012)

(*continued*)

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Table 4. Continued

Constructs	Items	Sources
Sensory Brand Experience (SBE)	SBE1. While browsing the online store, the brand engages multiple senses through its design and presentation. SBE2. The website delivers a high degree of sensory stimulation through its visuals, layout, and interactive features. SBE3. The brand's digital presence contains few sensory elements. (reverse-coded) SBE4. The brand's online environment feels sensorially distinct from that of other brands. SBE5. The sensory features of the brand's website contribute to its differentiation from competitors. SBE6. I perceive this brand as distinctive in terms of its sensory experience within the online environment. SBE7. My sensory experience while engaging with this brand online makes it highly recognizable compared to others. SBE8. The sensory characteristics presented on the website align with what I seek as a consumer. SBE9. The brand's sensory style in its digital environment feels appropriate to the cultural and geographic context in which I live. SBE10. The brand's sensory presentation online resonates with aspects of my identity, such as my age, gender, or social background. SBE11. The digital sensory elements of the brand reflect aspects of my personality. SBE12. The sensory tone conveyed by the brand aligns with my core personal values	Gao and Lan (2020), Ellen *et al.* (2000), Netemeyer *et al.* (2004), Bruhn *et al.* (2012)

(*continued*)

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Table 4. Continued

Constructs	Items	Sources
Consumer Sensory Orientation (CSO)	CSO1. Do you become easily overwhelmed by intense sensory input? CSO2. Do you tend to notice subtle details in your surroundings? CSO3. Are you affected by the emotional states of others? CSO4. Would you describe yourself as particularly sensitive to physical pain? CSO5. During busy days, do you feel the need to retreat—into bed, a dark room, or any quiet space—to gain privacy and relief from stimulation? CSO6. Are you especially sensitive to the effects of caffeine? CSO7. Do you feel overwhelmed by stimuli such as bright lights, strong odors, rough textures, or nearby sirens? CSO8. Would you say you have a rich and complex inner life? CSO9. Do loud sounds make you feel uncomfortable? CSO10. Are you deeply moved by artistic expressions or music? CSO11. Does your nervous system ever feel so overstimulated that you need to isolate yourself? CSO12. Are you a conscientious person? CSO13. Do you startle easily? CSO14. Do you become unsettled when faced with a high volume of tasks in a short period of time? CSO15. When others are physically uncomfortable, do you instinctively know how to improve the environment—such as adjusting lighting or seating? CSO16. Do you become irritated when asked to do too many things at once? CSO17. Do you make a conscious effort to avoid mistakes or lapses in memory? CSO18. Do you deliberately avoid watching violent films or television programs? CSO19. Do you feel overstimulated when there is a lot happening around you? CSO20. Does extreme hunger strongly affect your mood or ability to concentrate? CSO21. Do life changes tend to unsettle you? CSO22. Do you take notice of and enjoy subtle or refined scents, tastes, sounds, or works of art? CSO23. Do you find it unpleasant to deal with multiple stimuli at the same time? CSO24. Is avoiding upsetting or overwhelming situations a high priority in your life? CSO25. Are you disturbed by intense sensory input, such as loud noise or chaotic environments? CSO26. When you must compete or be observed while performing a task, do you become so anxious or shaky that your performance declines? CSO27. As a child, did your parents or teachers view you as particularly sensitive or shy?	Aron and Aron (1997a, b)

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Table 5. Reliability and validity assessment

		Factor loadings	Cronbach's Alpha	CR	AVE	Corrected item-total correlation
Experience Perceived Value (EPV)	EPV1	0.943	0.996	0.992	0.874	0.963
	EPV2	0.935				0.963
	EPV3	0.944				0.970
	EPV4	0.934				0.959
	EPV5	0.931				0.965
	EPV6	0.939				0.967
	EPV7	0.945				0.970
	EPV8	0.924				0.955
	EPV9	0.934				0.965
	EPV10	0.931				0.961
	EPV11	0.930				0.960
	EPV12	0.940				0.970
	EPV13	0.926				0.958
	EPV14	0.938				0.962
	EPV15	0.936				0.963
	EPV16	0.934				0.962
	EPV17	0.930				0.956
Perceived personalization (PP)	PP1	0.923	0.973	0.964	0.842	0.923
	PP2	0.917				0.921
	PP3	0.914				0.920
	PP4	0.915				0.923
	PP5	0.919				0.920
Sensory Brand Experience (SBE)	SBE1	0.904	0.987	0.981	0.815	0.923
	SBE2	0.896				0.920
	SBE3	0.914				0.930
	SBE4	0.886				0.910
	SBE5	0.908				0.928
	SBE6	0.906				0.917
	SBE7	0.897				0.922
	SBE8	0.897				0.919
	SBE9	0.913				0.926
	SBE10	0.911				0.924
	SBE11	0.898				0.916
	SBE12	0.900				0.922
Consumer Sensory Orientation (CSO)	CSO1	0.941	0.995	0.995	0.877	0.937
	CSO2	0.938				0.937
	CSO3	0.934				0.934
	CSO4	0.936				0.934
	CSO5	0.936				0.938
	CSO6	0.935				0.933
	CSO7	0.938				0.935
	CSO8	0.939				0.936
	CSO9	0.938				0.937
	CSO10	0.929				0.926
	CSO11	0.934				0.930
	CSO12	0.942				0.941
	CSO13	0.937				0.937
	CSO14	0.934				0.935
	CSO15	0.937				0.934
	CSO16	0.938				0.939
	CSO17	0.940				0.938
	CSO18	0.942				0.941
	CSO19	0.937				0.937
	CSO20	0.941				0.940
	CSO21	0.934				0.937
	CSO22	0.938				0.937
	CSO23	0.931				0.934
	CSO24	0.928				0.930
	CSO25	0.934				0.933
	CSO26	0.931				0.933
	CSO27	0.944				0.943

Source(s): Authors' own work

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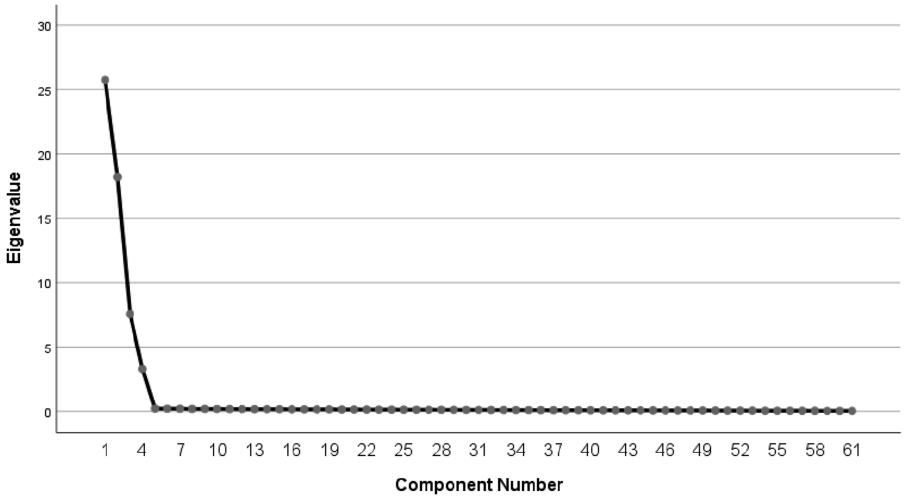


Figure 2. Scree plot. Source: Authors' own work

Discriminant validity was verified using the Fornell–Larcker criterion: the square root of each construct's AVE was greater than its correlations with other constructs (Table 6). Despite significant correlations among some variables, no conceptual overlap was detected.

5. Results

5.1 Hypothesis testing

Descriptive statistics (Table 7) show that the main variables (PP = 2.93; SBE = 3.06; CSO = 2.95; EPV = 3.00) are symmetrically distributed around the scale midpoint, with standard deviations between 1.32 and 1.59. Skewness and kurtosis remain within acceptable ranges, supporting the use of parametric analysis.

Hierarchical regression analysis (Table 8) was conducted to examine the effects of perceived personalization, brand sensory experience, and consumer sensory orientation on the experiential value attributed to in-store interactions. The stepwise inclusion of predictors allows assessment of changes in explanatory power as both main and interaction effects are introduced.

In the first model, which included age as the sole control variable, no statistically significant or theoretically relevant association with experiential value was observed ($F = 0.265$, $p = 0.607$), and explained variance was negligible. This result confirms that age does not interfere with the relationships of theoretical interest.

Table 6. Correlations and discriminant validity

	PP	SBE	CSO	EPV
PP	*0.917*			
SBE	0.089	*0.902*		
CSO	−0.109*	−0.027	*0.936*	
EPV	−0.307**	0.436**	0.189**	*0.934*

Note(s): *. Correlation is significant at the 0.05 level (2-tailed). **. Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed)

Source(s): Authors' own work

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Table 7. Descriptive statistics

	Mean	Std. deviation	Variance	Skewness		Kurtosis	
	Statistic	Statistic	Statistic	Statistic	Std. error	Statistic	Std. error
PP	2.93	1.366	1.868	0.045	0.116	−1.340	0.231
SBE	3.06	1.324	1.754	−0.060	0.116	−1.270	0.231
CSO	2.95	1.374	1.888	0.019	0.116	−1.388	0.231
EPV	3.00	1.597	2.551	0.027	0.116	−1.635	0.231

Source(s): Authors' own work

Table 8. Unstandardized regression estimates

	Experience perceived value (EPV)					
	Model 1		Model 2		Model 3	
	B	Sig	B	Sig	B	Sig
Constant	2.878 (0.250)	0.000	1.897 (0.324)	0.000	2.652 (0.486)	0.000
Direct effects						
PP			−0.388 (0046)	0.000	0.133 (0.102)	0.193
SBE			0.567 (0.047)	0.000	−0.195 (0.109)	0.074
CSO			0.192 (0.045)	0.000	−0.072 (0.136)	0.597
Moderating effects						
PP x CSO					−0.171 (0.032)	0.000
SBE x CSO					0.244 (0.033)	0.000
Controls						
Age	0.003 (0.006)	0.607	−0.002 (0.005)	0.739	0.000 (0.005)	0.928
R^2	0.001		0.338		0.437	

Note(s): Standard errors reported in parentheses. Abbreviations: Perceived personalization (PP), Sensory Brand Experience (SBE) and Consumer Sensory Orientation (CSO)

Source(s): Authors' own work

The second model produced a substantial increase in explained variance ($R^2 = 33.8\%$, adjusted $R^2 = 33.2\%$, $F(4, 440) = 56.135$, $p < 0.001$). Brand sensory experience showed the strongest positive association with experiential value ($B = 0.567$, $p < 0.001$), indicating that richer sensory brand interactions are linked to higher evaluations of the physical store experience. Consumer sensory orientation was also positively associated with experiential value ($B = 0.192$, $p < 0.001$), supporting the relevance of individual differences in perceptual sensitivity. These effects are particularly meaningful given that more than 60% of the sample is under 40 years of age and 45.6% report frequent online purchasing, suggesting high exposure to multisensory digital branding and heightened sensitivity to cross-channel coherence.

In contrast, perceived personalization exhibited a significant negative association with experiential value ($B = -0.388$, $p < 0.001$). This inverse relationship suggests potential symbolic overload when high levels of personalization occur in highly stimulating physical environments, pointing to a possibly nonlinear personalization–value relationship. This pattern is consistent with the high digital familiarity of the sample, for whom personalization may represent a normative expectation and may be perceived as artificial, intrusive, or emotionally flat when not supported by authentic in-store experiences.

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The third model incorporated interaction terms between sensory orientation and the two main predictors, further increasing explanatory power (R^2 = 43.7%, adjusted R^2 = 42.9%, F(6, 438) = 56.695, $p < 0.001$). Once interactions were included, the direct effects of perceived personalization (B = 0.133, $p = 0.193$), brand sensory experience (B = −0.195, $p = 0.074$), and sensory orientation (B = −0.072, $p = 0.597$) were no longer statistically significant, indicating that their effects on experiential value are conditional rather than independent.

A significant negative interaction emerged between perceived personalization and sensory orientation (B = −0.171, $p < 0.001$), showing that the association between personalization and experiential value weakens as sensory orientation increases. This moderating effect may be reinforced by the cultural composition of the sample, which includes a high proportion of participants from Latin America, Asia, and Africa, contexts where sensory symbolism, emotional depth, and social meaning are central to brand evaluation. For highly sensitive consumers, personalization disconnected from meaningful in-store experiences may be interpreted as lacking authenticity, as illustrated in Figure 3.

Conversely, the interaction between brand sensory experience and consumer sensory orientation was positive and significant (B = 0.244, $p < 0.001$), indicating that sensory stimuli exert a stronger influence on experiential evaluations among consumers with high sensory orientation. This finding aligns with the sample's demographic profile, characterized by balanced gender representation and a predominance of experience-oriented age groups, who typically respond more favorably to symbolic and multisensory retail environments. In such cases, coherent and integrated sensory stimulation is associated with experiences that are more intense, emotionally resonant, and symbolically meaningful (Figure 4).

Bootstrap analysis based on 1,000 resamples (Table 9) confirmed the robustness of the moderated model. The BCa confidence intervals supported the negative interaction between perceived personalization and sensory orientation (CI: −0.234 to −0.112, $p = 0.001$) and the positive interaction between brand sensory experience and sensory orientation (CI: 0.181 to 0.307, $p = 0.001$). These results reinforce the central premise of the study: experiential value is not generated by isolated stimuli but by the interaction between individual predispositions and environmental characteristics. The loss of significance of direct effects under resampling strengthens, rather than weakens, the theoretical coherence of the model by emphasizing conditional mechanisms. Neither the intercept nor the control variable showed significant effects, confirming model parsimony and reducing the need for sociodemographic segmentation.

Table 10 summarizes the hypotheses supported and rejected based on the regression results.

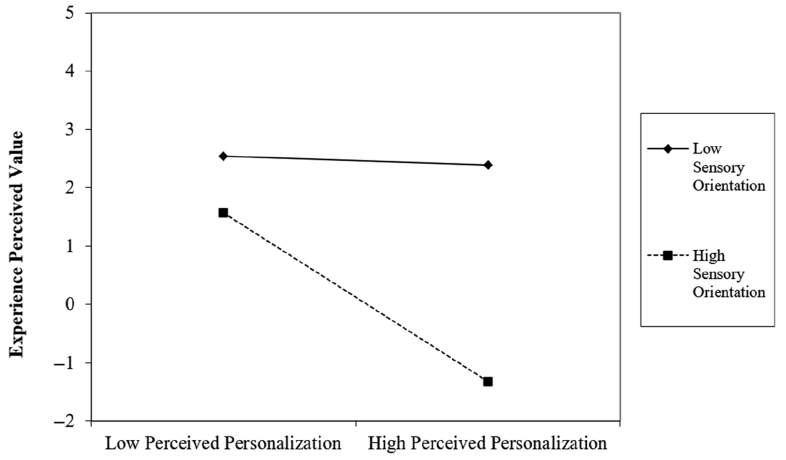


Figure 3. Interaction perceived personalization and sensory orientation. Source: Authors' own work

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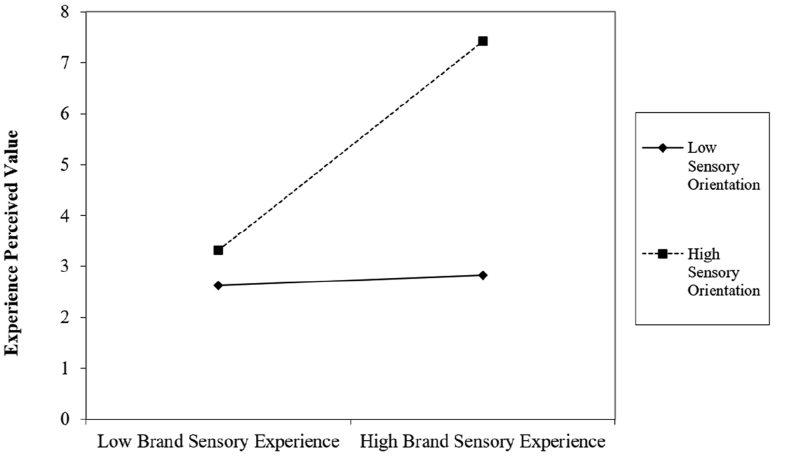


Figure 4. Interaction brand sensory experience and consumer sensory orientation. Source: Authors' own work

Table 9. Bootstrap for coefficients

		Bootstrap[a]				
Model	B	Bias	Std. Error	Sig. (2-Tailed)	BCa 95% confidence interval Lower	Upper
(Constant)	2.652	−0.007	0.542	0.001	1.522	3.715
PP	0.133	0.001	0.107	0.223	−0.086	0.349
SBE	−0.195	0.005	0.118	0.098	−0.429	0.070
CSO	−0.072	0.005	0.149	0.637	−0.383	0.249
PP x CSO	−0.171	−0.001	0.031	0.001	−0.234	−0.112
SBE x CSO	0.244	0.000	0.032	0.001	0.181	0.307
Age	0.000	0.000	0.005	0.912	−0.009	0.009

Note(s): [a]Bootstrap results are based on 1,000 bootstrap samples
Source(s): Authors' own work

Table 10. Summary of accepted and rejected hypotheses

Hypothesis	Expected result	Empirical result	Conclusion
H1	Negative and significant coefficient of PP.	Supported	Personalization is associated with a lower in-store experiential value
H2	Positive and significant coefficient of SBE.	Supported	Web-based sensory cues enhance perceived in-store value
H3	Significant negative interaction PP × CSO.	Supported	Sensory orientation reduces the negative impact of digital personalization
H4	Significant positive interaction SBE × CSO.	Supported	Sensory orientation strengthens the influence of sensory brand experience

Source(s): Authors' own work

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5.2 Discussion

The findings call for a reconsideration of the linear transfer model in omnichannel contexts, showing that experiential value depends not solely on digital stimuli but on the articulation between expectations and their sensory confirmation in physical settings. This challenges the notion of automatic channel continuity by demonstrating that the consumer experience is shaped by aesthetic and emotional coherence, as well as by perceptual sensitivity.

The negative association between digital personalization and in-store evaluations suggests that, when not sensorially translated, hyper-personalization may result in overstimulation or symbolic emptiness. High sensory orientation consumers are particularly likely to detect emotional inconsistencies between online content and in-store environments, perceiving them as a rupture in the brand's relational promise. This underlines the fragility of the emotional bond when technology substitutes rather than complements experiential authenticity.

In contrast, sensory stimuli embedded in digital communication enhance experiential value when mirrored in physical environments. This effect intensifies among perceptually sensitive consumers, for whom aesthetic congruence fosters fluency and emotional immersion. Sensory coherence across channels not only enhances experience but contributes to a coherent brand narrative.

The absence of significant direct effects and the predominance of interaction effects in the final model highlight that omnichannel experiences arise from relational configurations between consumers and environments, not isolated stimuli. This is especially relevant in fashion, where symbolic and affective dimensions are central to value construction. Perceptual diversity, therefore, is not residual but a core element in shaping experiential interpretations.

From a normative standpoint, the results raise ethical concerns about personalization algorithms in symbolically charged contexts. If personalization leads to emotional fatigue or dissonance, it may erode trust and authenticity, particularly among culturally sensitive audiences. This signals a need for regulatory frameworks that safeguard not only data privacy but also emotional integrity and transparency in persuasive technologies.

In a landscape where fashion brands increasingly communicate sustainability online, the findings further suggest that ethical narratives must be sensorially translated to achieve credibility. Sustainability cannot remain at the level of digital discourse; it must be expressed through materials, atmospheres, and stimuli that embody these values in the physical space, especially for consumers who assign high symbolic importance to such commitments.

Overall, the study indicates that designing effective omnichannel experiences requires understanding the interaction between technology, perception, and symbolism as an integrated ecosystem, where sensory coherence and experiential diversity become strategic levers for value creation.

6. Implications

6.1 Theoretical implications

This study advances the understanding of experiential value in omnichannel contexts by demonstrating that perceptions formed in digital environments do not transfer automatically to the physical store, but are shaped by consumers' perceptual traits and the degree of sensory coherence across channels. The findings directly address RQ1, revealing that website personalization may not only fail to enhance the in-store experience, but can diminish it for consumers with high sensory sensitivity. This challenges the prevailing view in the literature that personalization yields universal benefits across touchpoints (Alimamy and Gnoth, 2022), and raises concerns about its effectiveness when digitally generated expectations are not matched in the physical setting (Riegger, 2020; Tyrväinen *et al*., 2020).

The observed negative effect of personalization on experiential value—statistically robust and particularly salient among individuals with high sensory orientation—suggests that such consumers may perceive personalization as artificial, intrusive, or emotionally hollow. According to Expectancy-Disconfirmation Theory (Oliver, 1980), these consumers

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experience dissonance when symbolic or affective digital promises are not confirmed in-store. Therefore, this study nuances prior assumptions by showing that personalization is not universally beneficial but potentially high-risk in sensory-intensive contexts.

Conversely, digital sensory brand experience is shown to positively influence in-store experiential value, especially for consumers with strong sensory orientation. This extends Schema Theory (Fiske and Taylor, 1991) by evidencing that online sensory cues not only activate anticipatory mental representations but also establish interpretive schemas that enhance perceptual fluency and reinforce symbolic meaning when channel congruence is present. The positive value transfer confirmed by a significant interaction effect highlights the importance of aesthetic, atmospheric, and emotional coherence across channels. These findings also reinforce recent contributions on the role of digital sensory stimuli in shaping emotional expectations (Okuda and Rybak, 2023; Shahid *et al*., 2022), which had not previously been empirically connected to their offline translation.

With respect to RQ2, the results confirm the moderating role of sensory orientation in explaining how value transfer occurs across channels. This variable allows the model to move beyond approaches limited to sociodemographic or attitudinal factors (Bo *et al*., 2023), introducing a psychographic dimension that is key to understanding hybrid experiences. Sensory orientation functions not as a static trait but as a dynamic modulator that determines whether digital stimuli—personalized or sensory—are perceived as coherent, meaningful, or dissonant. The disappearance of direct effects when interactions are introduced supports this interpretation: experiential value arises from combinations of individual predispositions and contextual features, not isolated stimuli.

The study makes a dual theoretical contribution. It challenges the dominant functionalist view in omnichannel research, which assumes equivalence among channels and inherent positivity in digital stimuli (Lemon and Verhoef, 2016; Melis *et al*., 2015). Simultaneously, it proposes a model that distinguishes between personalization and sensory experience as separate mechanisms whose effects depend on sensory orientation. In doing so, it expands the conceptual scope of Expectancy-Disconfirmation Theory by placing it within a symbolic and multisensory framework, while also contributing to the development of Schema Theory in hybrid consumption contexts. By incorporating technological, perceptual, and psychographic interactions, the study provides a more nuanced and experience-sensitive framework for analyzing omnichannel fashion consumption.

6.2 Managerial implications

The findings offer strategic guidance for professionals in fashion retail, particularly those responsible for marketing, customer experience, digital interfaces, and in-store operations within omnichannel models. In a context of growing integration between digital and physical domains, the results call for a more refined approach to experience design that considers how digital stimuli shape perceptions of physical spaces.

A central practical insight is that algorithmic personalization does not inherently enhance the customer experience. Its impact may be counterproductive when personalized digital content creates symbolic or sensory expectations that the physical environment cannot fulfill. For digital marketing professionals, this underscores the importance of aligning personalized messages with the store's actual sensory and symbolic attributes, especially when targeting consumers with high sensory orientation, who are more sensitive to discrepancies between anticipated and lived experiences.

Customer experience designers should prioritize not only visual and functional consistency but also emotional and sensory coherence. This could involve harmonizing elements such as soundscapes or color palettes between digital and physical channels, and ensuring that values emphasized online—such as exclusivity, warmth, or sustainability—are tangibly expressed in-store. Rather than merely facilitating cross-platform transitions, the goal is to construct a coherent emotional narrative across the consumer journey.

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The digital sensory experience also emerges as a value-enhancing element, especially for consumers with strong perceptual sensitivity. Strategy and branding teams can thus view immersive digital environments not only as engagement tools but also as mechanisms that shape schemas guiding the in-store experience. Features like virtual fitting rooms, 3D simulations, or audiovisual storytelling function as expectation generators that influence how physical spaces are perceived in terms of quality and satisfaction.

Visual merchandising and point-of-sale teams can apply these insights by ensuring that in-store sensory dimensions reinforce the expectations set online. If the digital brand image emphasizes sophistication and immersion, this identity should be reflected in atmospheric elements such as music, lighting, and textures. In fashion retail, where product perception is shaped by aesthetic and affective codes, such sensory alignment can significantly impact conversion and loyalty.

For analytics and segmentation teams, the study opens opportunities for refining personalization strategies through psychographic segmentation based on sensory orientation. Integrating this variable into personalization processes would allow for adjustments in the intensity and type of stimuli delivered, better matching users' perceptual profiles and reducing the risk of experiential dissonance. This would enable more effective, sensitivity-aware omnichannel campaigns.

Overall, the study offers fashion retailers an empirical basis for developing emotionally coherent, sensorially integrated strategies that account for consumers' perceptual diversity. Rather than promoting universal personalization practices, the findings advocate for critical engagement with personalization technologies and a renewed emphasis on sensory experience as a key bridge between digital and physical brand environments.

Table 11 outlines the main theoretical contributions and managerial implications derived from the study, highlighting how the results advance current frameworks and offer actionable insights for omnichannel retail strategy.

Table 11. Summary of theoretical contributions and practical implications

Theoretical contribution	Practical implication
Challenges the assumption that online personalization is universally positive in omnichannel contexts, showing it may reduce in-store experiential value when expectations are unmet.	Marketing and UX teams should avoid over-personalizing digital touchpoints unless the physical store can fulfill symbolic and sensory expectations. Focus should shift to coherent rather than maximal personalization
Demonstrates that consumer sensory orientation moderates the effect of digital stimuli on in-store evaluations, underscoring the relevance of psychographic traits in cross-channel experience	Customer segmentation should include sensory sensitivity to align digital and physical experiences. Data and CRM teams can enhance targeting through psychographic profiling
Confirms that digital sensory brand experiences act as priming mechanisms enhancing in-store experiential value when sensory congruence exists	Digital branding should invest in immersive, sensorially rich interfaces (e.g. interactive visuals, audio, textures) to condition positive physical experiences
Expands Expectancy-Disconfirmation Theory by applying it to symbolic and sensory dimensions in omnichannel contexts, beyond functional expectations	Brand strategists and retail designers must ensure emotional and atmospheric continuity across channels to minimize dissonance
Introduces an interaction-based model of experiential value construction, emphasizing dynamic interplay between individual dispositions and environmental features	CX managers should design flexible, adaptive journeys reflecting perceptual diversity. Sensory and symbolic coherence becomes a strategic advantage

Source(s): Authors' own work

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6.3 Limitations and further research

While this study advances understanding of how digital experiences affect experiential value in physical retail, several limitations must be noted. The cross-sectional quasi-experimental design precludes causal inference, so findings should be interpreted as dispositional rather than deterministic. Reliance on self-reported data introduces biases—retrospective reconstruction, affective priming, social desirability—that may affect accuracy.

Allowing participants to choose brands enhances contextual relevance but introduces uncontrolled variability in attributes such as price positioning, store design, or symbolic identity, which may moderate effects. Future studies could address this via segmentation by brand type or experimental manipulation of brand features.

Ecological validity is limited by the absence of behavioral or observational measures, and the unidimensional treatment of personalization may mask distinct effects of its components (e.g. algorithmic recommendations, interface customization). Future research should deconstruct the construct to capture specific modalities.

Although geographically diverse, the sample lacked control over brand category or retail segment (e.g. luxury vs. fast fashion), limiting generalizability. Experimental designs and stratified sampling are recommended to enhance theoretical precision in modeling omnichannel experience formation.

7. Conclusion

This study investigated how perceived personalization and digital sensory brand stimulation influence the experiential value attributed to physical store visits, and whether consumer sensory orientation moderates these effects. Results confirm that value transfer in omnichannel contexts is not uniform but shaped by symbolic and perceptual variables.

Online sensory brand experience enhanced offline experiential value, whereas perceived personalization showed a negative effect when lacking sensory or symbolic continuity. Sensory orientation moderated these effects—diminishing personalization's impact and amplifying that of sensory stimuli. Highly sensitive consumers responded more to multisensory coherence and less to emotionally empty personalization.

Theoretically, the study challenges the assumption that personalization universally enhances value, highlights the role of digital sensory branding in expectation formation, and introduces sensory orientation as a critical moderator—advancing a more nuanced model that connects perceptual psychology with omnichannel consumer behavior.

The research supports a granular view of omnichannel experience, where success relies not only on coherent messaging but on individual interpretation across touchpoints—informing both theory and brand strategy.

Findings should be viewed in light of the quasi-experimental design, which lacked randomized stimulus assignment. Future research should adopt experimental or longitudinal approaches to explore causal mechanisms.

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Corresponding author
Coral Cenizo can be contacted at: coral.cenizoruizbravo@ceu.es

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